unsurprisingly, went to Rahul Gandhi. Every Congress leader who appeared on television on counting day hailed Rahul's 'dynamic' leadership. Dr Singh's contribution as the incumbent prime minister seemed but a footnote. The fact that the Congress had won as many as twenty-one seats in Rahul's home state of Uttar Pradesh only added to the euphoria around the Congress's 'yuvraj'. It only seemed a matter of time that the 'prince' would be crowned. 'Just you wait and see, in a year or two Dr Singh will step aside and Rahul will take over,' was a refrain one heard from more than one Congressman. Sycophancy Congress-style had just received a new lease of life.

There was another group within the Congress which felt that Rahul should become a minister in the new government. They suggested that Rahul become either rural development or human resource development minister since he had strong views on rural uplift and education. 'He refused us point-blank,' says a member of that group. 'His view was that he could only focus on one thing at a time and at that moment he was obsessed with "democratizing" the Youth Congress and NSUI.' The truth is, the idea of a Gandhi family member working under another prime minister also made some Congressmen uneasy, though Indira Gandhi did serve briefly as information and broadcasting minister under Lal Bahadur Shastri in the 1960s.

It wasn't just loyal Congress family courtiers who were heaping praise on Rahul. There were enough of us in the media who were praising Rahul's youthful enthusiasm as a crucial factor in the ruling alliance's triumph. That year, the CNN-IBN Indian of the Year award in the category of politics was awarded to Rahul Gandhi. At the jury meeting chaired by eminent jurist Soli Sorabjee, the verdict was unanimous. 'For galvanizing the Congress cadres, for reaching out to young India and enthusing millions of Indians to vote for the Congress, the CNN-IBN Indian of the Year award goes to Rahul Gandhi,' read the citation.

In hindsight, we were wrong. Yes, Rahul had worked hard; yes, the Gandhi family name had helped the Congress in Uttar Pradesh where the voter was looking for an alternative at the national level to the BSP and the